

YOUR WEEKLY DECISION · WHAT IT'S REALLY WORTH

# What's Your Business *Really* Worth?

BY RJ FINLEY

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There's a lot you can tell about a person from their home. The way it's laid out, what they chose to spend money on, the corners they were fine cutting and the ones they weren't. Walk into someone's house and within a few minutes you have a decent sense of what they care about, because a home tends to become a reflection of the person who made it.

Anyone who has built a house, or lived through even a serious renovation, knows it's less a project than a long process of becoming. It starts with a vision, and then it turns into a thousand small decisions made over months, a good number of them later at night than you'd like, until one day the thing is finished and it isn't just a structure anymore. It's a reflection of who you are. Building a business feels the same way, which is exactly why selling one is so complicated.

You laid the foundation and weathered the storms that came after, added on when things were good, tore parts down when they weren't, and rebuilt until the whole thing felt like yours. So when it finally comes time to sell, it's only natural to believe it's worth more than any outsider could understand, because no one standing on the outside watched what it took to build.

The difficult truth, and I say this with real respect for everything you've poured in, is that a business gets valued the same way a home does. Not on what it means to you and your family, but on how well it works for the person who's buying it.

That's the gap almost every founder runs into, the distance between the builder and the buyer. You're remembering the sweat equity and the risks and the nights you didn't sleep, while the buyer is standing in the doorway asking an entirely different set of questions. They want to know whether the structure is sound, whether the systems are modern or just familiar, whether the place can run without the person who built it, and how it compares to the other businesses they're weighing at the same time. Neither view is wrong. Your connection to it is real and it matters, but the market pays for

reliability, for scalability, and for a return it can count on, so the work worth doing is making the business into something a stranger can walk into and trust.

In practice that comes down to three things, and each of them has a clean parallel to selling a house.

The first is getting the foundation in order, which for a business means clean, consistent financials. A buyer studies your books the way a homebuyer studies a slab, looking for cracks, and if your reporting is messy or leans heavily on your personal judgment to make sense, that uncertainty shows up as risk they'll price against you. Standardizing the reporting, properly separating personal and business expenses, and normalizing earnings so they reflect what the company truly makes is the equivalent of staging a home before a showing. The clearer the picture, the more confident the buyer, and confident buyers tend to pay more.

The second is making sure the business is something someone else could step into, because a company that can't run without its owner is a beautiful house with no plumbing. That means building a leadership team that can decide things when you're not in the room, documenting the way the work gets done, and slowly removing yourself from the center of every important relationship. This matters even more in a family business, where so much of the value quietly lives in trust that would otherwise walk out the door with you: the vendor who deals with you because it's you, the employees loyal to you personally, the customers who call your cell instead of the office. A real succession plan protects the relational capital your family spent years building, and it lowers the risk a buyer sees when they picture you gone.

The third is understanding the market you're actually selling into, because even a beautiful home won't sell for more than the street will bear. A professional valuation tells you what companies like yours are trading for and, just as usefully, what you could change to move that number, and the owners who benefit most are the ones who ask the question early. A valuation three to five years ahead of a sale gives you time to fix the things that drive the price, while a valuation the month before you sell mostly just confirms what you're stuck with.

What it comes down to is that after years, sometimes decades, of building something remarkable, the value at the end was never only in what you built. It lives in how well the thing stands on its own once you finally let go of it. A valuation isn't an attempt to shrink your life's work into a single number, it's a way of telling the true story of its strength, its people, its systems, and everything it could still become. Just like a great home, the better it's built and the more ready it is for someone else to live in, the more it's worth.

Most of what gets built these days is spec houses, cookie-cutter floor plans that nobody remembers walking through.

**THIS WEEK'S DECISION**

*This week, decide whether you're going to leave your business as a spec house, or start making the deliberate moves now that turn it into the kind of custom home a buyer can't stop thinking about.*

This is the kind of conversation I have with owners all the time, long before anyone's actually selling. If you'd want to think through what your business is worth and where the gaps are, my calendar's here: <https://app.greminders.com/c/rj/decisionlabinit>

*Know a business owner who's a few years out from selling? Forward this along. The best time to learn what something's worth is long before you have to sell it.*

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